

little chef's hats, grab a ladle, and begin serving up meals for their classmates.

After the kids have eaten—while sitting in the classroom, learning about the benefits of eating healthy vegetables(!)—no teachers or kitchen staff come in and clean up their mess. It's the students' 'honourable duty' to clean everything away and do the dishes.

'It's seen as a sacred ritual in Japan,' Matt explained.

The dishonourable mealtime

I returned home from Japan like a sharpened chopstick, ready to instigate our very own honourable mealtimes at the Pape household.

It did not go well.

Most nights my wife makes healthy, nutritious meals, sourced from our veggie garden. And, because I know Liz is reading this, I need to say that she's actually a great cook, and we love her meals. Really, we do.

I came down for dinner, the boys looked unsettled at the table.

'I don't like it,' announced the oldest, sounding like a dead ringer for Pauline the fish 'n' chip lady.

'I don't like it!' cried my two-year-old.

'Oh please, you're just copying your older brother!' I said, putting on my best dad voice. 'I'm sure it's . . . oh . . . it's apricot chicken . . . again.'

(My wife's apricot chicken is a motley mix of citrus, chicken . . . and onions? It's a dish that none of us like, but one that she stoically persists in trying to master.)

At that point Liz threw down her fork and said some very dishonourable things.

And then we all sat in silence.

And then the two-year-old tipped his bowl on his head.